buried/daylight

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40800219.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by n7punk

Summary

Adora is just trying to make sure nothing drives Catra away again, but she might do it on her own by being overbearing. They need to learn how to communicate, but old habits die hard and Adora has never been known for her restraint. Catra has never known how to back down and she likes to be talked down to even less than she likes to be vulnerable.
(Or, how Catradora ~~-~~and their issues ~~-~~fit together after it all)

Notes

This came out a little one-sided just because it' s from Adora's perspective, but both these bitches got issues lol

See the end of the work for more notes

The first full day in Bright Moon after it all is mostly a whirlwind. There's so much to do – a recently-occupied castle to restore from its ravaging, a planet of displaced citizens to guide into peace, hundreds of clones that need to be talked down, helped, and in some cases fought, the list goes on – and every moment from when they leave their room in the morning until dinner finds them pulled in multiple directions.

Adora isnt allowed to go in some of them. Catra noticed that She-ra's lingering injuries were causing her pain on the way back last night, and when Adora forces herself to stand from bed the next morning, it's still there. Given how severe her injuries were, this might be the least they have lingered based on their initial intensity and she is sure she has the Heart to thank for that – and maybe Catra too, a little bit – but she still doesnt feel a hundred percent. She almost died. She didnt just have a foot in the door , Catra had to reach in and pull her out. Not even She-ra can walk away from that unaffected.

So Adora is benched. Because Catra is overprotective – always has been, even if she could rarely do anything about it – and because her friends are just plain protective. When Catra rats her out over breakfast Glimmer orders Adora to take it easy for the next few days. Short of the clones banding together again and launching an assault, She-ra isnt allowed out. Adora is having a hard time keeping She-ra *down* when she looks at Catra and sees her smiling, expression relaxed and her hand in Adora's, but she's managing it for now at least.

The first time things are almost calm all day is during dinner, and even then people flit in here and there to give an update, or ask one of the princesses what they should do, or because they just made their way back to Bright Moon for the first time and need to get their new orders. Dinner being interrupted was always rare before, but nothing is going to be normal for days, weeks, *ever again*. The war is over and their purpose, and thus their days, will change. The Princess Alliance had a whole meeting about it this morning.

"Is dinner usually like that?" Catra asks, her voice a bit hesitant, as they walk back to their room afterwards. Adora tilts her head, glancing over at her girlfriend. Catra has her left hand in Adora's, the two of them walking side-by-side in an empty hallway. It's late, far later than dinner almost ever is, but there was a lot to do. Outside of the timing – and the interruptions – they rarely have that many people over for dinner. Even after Alliance meetings, sometimes people would have already gone home, or not all of them would come down. There would be plenty more dinners for them to come to, after all. A normal group dinner like that after the last few months felt like a breath of fresh air, so of course everybody was there.

"Not always. That was like, family dinner. It's not usually every night. When I first joined those were just Glimmer, her mom, Bow, and sometimes me. Angella didn't trust me at first, or even like me very much despite what Glimmer said. My anxiety would be so bad through them, but over time she grew to like me and I got used to them. As we rebuilt the Princess Alliance they started joining in sometimes when we had meetings," Adora tells her, shrugging a little. Catra didn't seem too overwhelmed while they were at the table, and she did a pretty good job of joking around with Glimmer, but now that Adora's thinking about it there were definitely stretches where Catra wasn't talking.

Adora, often distracted with conversation herself, just put it down to Catra listening or eating. She thinks she would have noticed if Catra had made it all the way to distressed, but she still glances over her shoulder to look where Melog is trailing behind them. Melog blinks back at her. They don't seem tense and they aren't trying to comfort Catra either, so maybe she was just curious? It's a very different experience from shuffling into the cafeteria at the Horde or grabbing a quick ration. Everything to do with eating was a big adjustment – like most things were – after leaving the Fright Zone.

"It doesn't have to be like that. A lot of the time it's smaller, like when we were back on Darla. Usually we just grab some food from the kitchens. There's a smaller dining room attached there or we bring

food back to our rooms. We can just do that from now on if you want,"Adora of fers. She looks back to Catra to find her looking forward with her mouth set. She isn't frowning, but her expression isn't relaxed either . Every glimpse of Catra relaxed since they rescued her has felt like seeing the stars for the first time all over again. Adora will happily take all their meals in their room if it makes that line of tension go away.

"It' s fine. I can handle a *dinner*,"Catra replies. Her voice isn't angry , but the response still makes Adora frown. She doesn't know if she is imagining the defensive edge to her words. Adora is aware of Melog walking just a little closer behind them. She kind of wants to stop so she can turn Catra and look at her, but they're almost back to their room. She isn't going to drop this, but that' s a better place for a serious conversation than the hallway. The others will be coming this way soon as they come trickling out of the dining room.

"Catra, I just told you how anxious they used to make me. Y ou don't have to prove something by sitting through it. I ate on my own a lot at the beginning,"Adora tells her . She also ate alone a lot, or just with whatever member of the Alliance was hanging around that day, at the end when everyone was busy and tensions were high, but her concern right now is Catra shutting off. Catra lets out a sigh —or maybe a scoff —and doesn't say anything, still looking forward. Adora spots their door ahead.

Her heart is beating noticeably faster now. There have been times today where Catra made leaps forward, and others where she snapped and then quickly withdrew . There were even times when she was silent like right now, but somehow this feels the most significant of any of them. They're alone. Catra isn't being overwhelmed or surrounded by people she once considered enemies. It's just her and Adora right now , Melog trailing quietly right behind them.

She and Catra were enemies once too, even if they were everything else too. She thought, with all their history, she was the exception if there was ever going to be one, but maybe sometimes there just

isn't. Maybe it isn't as significant as the anxiety beating in her chest says it is. Catra is still holding her hand, after all. She isn't turning away, even if her expression is shuttering.

Adora seizes the opportunity to be useful – and get them alone – when they step within range of the door. She takes a long step forward to be the first to reach it, holding it for Catra. Catra ducks her head, some of the tension easing in her in favor of – is that embarrassment? Her tail lashes as she slips into the room, dropping Adora's hand to step inside. Adora holds the door for Melog too, but once they are both through she lets it thud shut and turns to Catra, who is still facing away to the room at large. She's about to speak when Catra beats her to it.

"It wasn't bad. It was just a lot," she says, her voice quiet. Adora watches Catra wrap an arm around herself, shifting her weight a little bit on her feet. She wants to believe her. She wants to accept this at face value, but Melog pads over to her and leans against her side, as if seeking comfort in Catra's stead. Adora drops her hand to pet their head as she thinks about her words.

"Well if *a lot* becomes *too much*, you don't have to do it. I know what it's like, Catra. I forced myself through them when I wasn't ready because I didn't want to fail Glimmer. You don't have to be proud about this," Adora tries, trying to thread the needle between understanding and firm. She has landed too far into harsh territory in the past, but she has also seen that sometimes she needs to call Catra out. She can't just let her hide and fester until she lashes out.

The details aren't a perfect match, but Adora sounds like a hypocrite even in her own head. She fails regardless. Catra hisses as soon as the words leave her mouth, turning around with her lip curled up and her body tensing. Her arms fall from around herself, almost dropping into a defensive position despite how she stays standing up in the same spot. There's a light in her eyes that Adora knows well.

"I'm not *you*. I don't have your problems, I've got my own shit to deal with. Back off," she bites out. Adora doesn't wince, but her breath

hitches and her shoulders hunch. For the third, maybe fourth, time today she watches Catra's eyes widen as she seems to realize what she has said—see the pain flash across someone's face—and then she pulls back again. She never moves from her spot, really, but she retreats into herself, glaring down at the floor as her tail wraps tightly around her legs. Her ears twitch as Adora takes a deep breath, pricking forward to listen despite her withdrawn body language.

"I'm terrified of you shutting down again, okay? Or letting it all build up until everything breaks down. And this," Adora cuts off, gesturing between them, "looks a lot like pride. You don't have to be strong here, Catra. It's just me. I'm not going to judge you for it. I just… don't want to lose you again," Adora says, starting off firm, maybe even a touch angry, but getting weaker by the end. It wasn't fair of Catra to lash out then, but yelling at her isn't going to help. They don't need to fight about this, they just need to *talk*.

Maybe asking Catra to talk about anything after the pressure of the day is too much, but Adora's kind of afraid that if they don't, Catra will start feeling like she's drowning from every extra weight she is forced to take on and leave again. Dinner is such an easy thing. There are a lot of things that are going to be hard and *have* to be, no other option or shortcut. Dinner doesn't even have to be on the list of concerns. They can do whatever Catra is comfortable with regardless of if there's a gathering in the dining hall.

Catra keeps looking down at the floor. After a moment, she curls her foot up and scratches at the tile a little with one of her toe claws. As least she doesn't bite back. Adora glances down at Melog. They pulled away when Catra first hissed, but now they're standing at Adora's side, their head ducked and face tilted up like they're trying to make eye contact with Catra. Their mane is blue as they mew softly.

"I'm trying," Catra says, her voice soft. Adora isn't sure which one of them she's talking to.

"I know ," Adora replies, her voice just as quiet. She's tired. The sun has set and they never even turned on the light upon entering the room, though there is plenty of moonlight pouring in through the balcony to see. Her body aches in odd places, the lingering reminders of yesterday's wounds making themselves known. A pessimistic part of Adora wonders if this conversation is going to be added onto the pile of things they need to talk about – if every time they try to address something it is going to go like this. Today, for all its faults, has been good. She wants to believe their days together can be like that, for the most part. She *does*, it's just all so fresh she has no proof aside from the strength of her convictions. Catra sighs, her shoulders falling with it and staying down.

"I'm sorry for snapping. But it's been too much today to – do this," Catra lifts her head, but her face is still turned to the side, just short of glaring at the wall. "I know you're trying to help. You're also being a dick," she adds. Her voice is soft. Adora snorts, feeling some of the tension release from the room. Cautiously, she steps forward. Melog doesn't bristle, instead following at her side. Adora takes that as permission to cross the gap between her and Catra, but she stops in front of her without trying to reach out.

"So are you," she says, her voice just as soft. Maybe it's just the hint of affection in her words, but the corner of Catra's mouth quirks up and her eyes flick over, finally meeting Adora's gaze. She looks tired, but relieved too. Adora reaches out now, running a hand down Catra's arm and carefully trying to take Catra's hand. Catra lets her, squeezing back. Catra takes a steadying breath, closing her eyes as she blows it out and turning her head to fully face Adora again. When she opens her eyes again, there's an anxious light there.

"You're not being a dick. You're just pushing. And I feel like I've been standing on a cliff all day," she acknowledges, her words a bit grumbling. Reluctant or regretful, it doesn't really matter , the tension in Adora's chest releases and she leans forward on her toes. Catra releases a small sound of surprise as Adora presses a kiss to her forehead, over her new bangs and near the base of her ear.

"Sorry . I was trying to keep you from going over some other time. We can talk about it later if it ends up being a problem," Adora promises her as she drops back to the flat of her feet. Catra nods, offering her the edge of a fleeting smile. Melog brushes against Adora's leg as they circle them both. They nuzzle a bit at Adora's lower back as if to scent mark it – Adora is *pretty* sure they can't do that – as they loop around. It soothes Adora. It has to mean Catra is calming down.

"- *A lot* doesn't have to mean bad. It was just..." Catra cuts off, looking away again and swallowing. "Later," she agrees. Adora lets out a breath, releasing Catra's hand so she can lift both arms and wrap them around her. Catra lets herself be pulled in, wrapping her own arms around Adora's waist and seeming happy to bury her face in her shoulder.

"I'm proud of you. For everything today, and especially for not punching Glimmer's minister when he sneered at you, and for this. Knowing your limits and all that. I know we both suck at it," Adora tells her, words sincere even if they are a bit muffled by the hug. Catra chuckles weakly, nuzzling her a little to get her head in a more comfortable position.

"Some more than others," Catra mumbles. Her voice is affectionate, so she's probably talking about Adora. Adora snorts, squeezing Catra a little closer.

"We've both got stuff to work on," Adora acknowledges. Catra's tail thuds against her leg.

"Yeah, like how we do *this*, but... later," Catra replies, tone derisive until the final word comes out almost like a sigh. Adora nods against her shoulder. Almost fighting isn't the ideal way to try to have a conversation and they both played a part in that, but at least it was only *almost*. She doesn't quite know if she can trust Catra yet to acknowledge when something is hard for her – admitting weakness, being vulnerable, is *hard* – but she knew even as she was doing it that she was disregarding what Catra was telling her.

After what she saw in their shared memories back in the Crystal Castle, she isn't so willing to take Catra's words for what they are, but if Catra has reached the point where she can be honest, then Adora's just being a dick and not trusting her. She doesn't know how she will know when they reach that point. Catra has been working so hard since they rescued her, but walking the line between trusting her and not letting her get away with the things that used to cause problems between them before is hard.

Add in Adora's own problems and she knows this will be far from their only fight as a couple. They will have fights, big ones, and she isn't lying to herself about that, but now that they've stepped back from a fight—and into each other's arms—she thinks they can recover from it.

"Wanna cuddle? We can do that now. And the bed's all made up, even," Adora offers. She feels a slight rumble in Catra's chest before she pulls back, easily trailing her hand to take Adora's again. Her expression is as soft as it is tired. All traces of the anger that sparked to life there earlier are gone.

"We can do whatever we want now," she returns, taking a step towards the bed that Adora gladly follows. She smiles to herself as they walk to the bed and then takes the risk on reaching out with her free hand and catching Catra's waist with it. Catra blushes as she follows Adora's gentle tug to face her, her eyes a little wide with surprise—or maybe hope.

"I want to kiss you," Adora decides, because she does, and she thinks it would be good for Catra to have the reminder that she loves her right now. She thinks Catra might have been angling for that, even, but she wants to make sure that she asks before doing this since the conversation was just tense. Catra's ears and tail twitch at once, flush evident on her cheeks as she takes a half step closer, their bodies fitting together like it's nothing. Adora smiles at her as Catra tilts her face up, both of them leaning in to meet at the same time. The kiss is a little fumbling still, but it's easy to adjust after their

lips have connected and then it's just *kissing Catra*, which is to say incredible.

There's a lot of shit between them, but Adora doesn't feel the same tension – anxiety, pessimism, whatever – that she felt by the door. Catra snapped, but she didn't explode. Neither of them handled that the best they could have, but it was okay. They made their way back to relaxed. They can work things out in small doses if they have to. She thinks this was progress, in the end. If nothing else, she learned a little more about where Catra's limits are and that will help her not push them in the future. Catra told her to stop and she listened. She hopes that counts for something.

She loves Catra. She has as many issues as her girlfriend does and she knows how much they would both sacrifice for this. It will be okay even when they fight. They're working on themselves and finding their middle ground. Just looking at Catra made her so happy all day and that was nothing compared to when they would talk or joke around like they used to. This – Catra in her life, in her arms – is worth fighting for and figuring out how to not fight *over*. They'll talk, when they're able, and they'll learn how to not push each other's buttons when they aren't.

All those thoughts, while comforting, are too big for when she has Catra in her arms. Adora focuses on tilting her head for a better angle and just enjoying Catra's arm wrapping around her waist and pulling her close. It will work. They will have to put in effort to *make* it work, but they'll do it. This is the reward waiting for them when they do, and Adora knows that she wants this no matter what it takes.

End Notes

Fics in my OotW verse this references: Adora's chronic pain from She-ra's healing factor, Adora having trouble keeping down She-ra.
This was supposed to be about Catra's experience with dinners/food post-Horde but I have literally no control over these two so it became about this instead. That fic is still coming if I can get them to cooperate, but this had to go be its own thing.
Update: you can find the fic here.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!